Mr. Burp

By Cora Sorenson

Stella is a verbal and bright 9-year-old. She often speaks quickly, almost to the point of stumbling over her own words.

STELLA: Gram always said, "He's just as cute as a button," and I always thought that was a really weird thing to say because I've never seen a button that was as cute as he was, but it's just a saying and sometimes sayings don't really make very much sense. Sorry. Sometimes I talk fast when I have a lot to say. Mom says it's because my mind is going fast and my mouth is trying to catch up with it. Which I think is just a nice way of saying I should talk slower. But he was a really neat lizard. His name was George Washington and he was about this big and bright green with little yellow polka-dots.

INTRODUCTION

9-year-old Stella had always been precocious, smart and fearless. But everything changed the day she was diagnosed with leukemia. Gone were perfect spelling tests, math homework and her arch-nemesis Janine Martin. Her new world was filled with doctor's appointments, whispers, worried looks and fear. But in the midst of it all, something extraordinary happened. From the depths of her imagination came Mr. Burp, a frightened monster who lived under her bed and was not afraid to cry. No one else could see him, but Mr. Burp arrived to help her face the darkness and remind her that even in the hardest times, wonder never truly disappears.

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STELLA: I came home from school one day and he was just lying there and not moving at all. He was dead. And I was really sad, but more than anything else, I wanted to know if GW was going to Heaven. And then Gram explained to me that when animals . . . ***die*** they go to a place called the Rainbow Bridge and they just play and have fun and wait for their people-owners to go with them to Heaven. It sounded really nice. So, I would pray at night and ask God, nicely, if he could just let GW go on to Heaven. I didn't think he should have to wait for me.

And that was when I started having the Really Bad Dreams. I would wake up really

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late at night and know that I'd just had one of them, but I couldn't remember what it was about. I knew that part of my brain knew it, but I couldn't find that part at all. Just things about being cold or a darkness so big it could swallow you up. That doesn't make any sense. It sounds like something a little kid would say, and I'm not a little kid anymore. In my dream I'd be super scared, trying to catch my breath, and I'd pinch myself and say, "Now you listen, Stella, you wake up right now!" and then I would. I'd wake up and I would go sit in the kitchen with all of the lights on until Mom or Dad would tell me I should go back to bed.

So, I was having one of these Really Bad Dreams with the big dark and the huge cold and, in my dream, I heard something coming from under my bed. In dreams, you always do the thing you should never ever do; so of course, I get down on the floor and I'm looking under the bed . . . and I'm trying to wake myself up, pinching myself, really, really hard. *(pinches herself, then reacts)* Holy Crud! I ***am*** awake. This isn't part of the Really Bad Dream anymore; this is a Really Bad Being Awake. My arm hurts cuz I pinched it so hard and under my bed, there's a monster.

I run as fast as I can downstairs to the kitchen and turn all of the lights on. Mom finds me there in the morning and says that maybe my bad dreams are getting worse. I do ***not*** say one word about the monster under my bed. I already have a nightmare problem, and I am not going to be the kid with the Overactive Imagination too. Or like Gram says, "Four quarters short of a dollar and headed upstream with no paddles!" I decided I was not going to think about him anymore, and anyway, he had probably gone away to hide under some other kid's bed and scare them. Like Janine Martin, because she's mean. That was on Friday, because . . . *(suddenly sad)* I had a doctor's appointment.

But [the monster] was still there that night and I slept in the kitchen. Mom said I needed to sleep in bed. He was there on Saturday, and I slept in the bathroom. Dad said I needed to sleep in bed. He was there on Sunday too, and I slept in my closet,

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where there were no monsters. I told Mom and Dad about him on Monday. They told me I had an overactive imagination and then Dad looked under the bed with a flashlight, but the monster was hiding and Dad didn't see him. And then Mom sang me to sleep, which is usually only for little kids, but I made an exception, what with the whole "I'm living with a monster under my bed" situation. *(hums a little of Home on the Range)*

So, I thought maybe the monster had gone away to scare Janine until I woke up in the middle of the night because this is a Very Big "Holy Crud" -- the monster was crying -- Lots of tears and snuffling crying. This was getting ridiculous! *(rolls her eyes)* It's hard to be afraid of a monster who's crying! I told him if he was trying to scare me, he was doing a ***really*** bad job. But he just kept crying. I was really tired and I had a math test the next day, so I did the one thing a kid should never do: tell him he might as well just sleep in bed with me. As long as he stopped crying and didn't snore. Like Gram says, "If you can't beat 'em, join 'em."

He was there every night. And he didn't snore at all, but he did burp sometimes. He was just a really good friend. He didn't make fun of me because I had the special classes at school for the advanced kids. He just listened . . . sometimes kids, even smart kids or strong kids, just need a friend.

I slipped up a couple of times. I did. Talked about Mr. Burp when I was eating my Captain Crunch or when Dad was helping me with my homework. And Mom and Dad would just smile and laugh. I wanted to explain that Mr. Burp wasn't like the Easter Bunny who lays chicken eggs or a fat man who breaks into your house at Christmas. He was just my friend . . . I'm not sure if he was something they could understand.

So, it wasn't very long ago, I was getting ready for bed -- and I got down tell Mr. Burp he could come to bed and um, he wasn't there. He wasn't there at all. I looked all over my room, in my closet, in my dresser, in my cupboards. And I wasn't going to say this, but I started crying because I couldn't find him. Mr. Burp told me that ***no matter what***,

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he was going to stay with me. And I believed him! No matter how tough things were or how bad I was hurting or how much I just wanted to be a 9-year-old kid who was happy all the time, he would be there for me. *(long pause, softly)* He would be there even though I was sick.

(yelling loudly) "Mr. Burp! Mr. Burp! I won't complain anymore. I promise. Please come back!" And I guess I yelled so loud that I woke my Mom and Dad and they came running out of their room. *(crying)* "I can't find Mr. Burp. I think he went away."

And you know what? My Mom started crying, and held me like I was a little baby. And she just kept saying, "I love you" and I kept saying, "I know, but I need to find Mr. Burp. If he's gone to the Rainbow Bridge already, is he going to wait for me? Am I going to the Rainbow Bridge too?" And you know what? She said he would wait for me. She told me that maybe I could make a stop at the Rainbow Bridge on my way to the other place I was going. A place with a lot of light and big pink clouds and . . . no pain. And I told her I was so scared. Scared for Mr. Burp . . . and for me. I didn't want Mr. Burp to be alone. And she told me that nobody was ever ***really*** alone. Ever. I just wish things were different sometimes. *(hums a bit of Home on the Range, holding back tears; she furiously wipes her eyes)*

Sorry. I promised Mr. Burp that I wouldn't get weepy. I'm not a little kid anymore. I did like going to school, though. It's hard to go to school when you're just so tired and when you have to go to so many doctor's appointments. My doctor is a really nice lady, but I don't think she's used to younger kids asking so many questions. Like when she delivered the Really Bad News to my parents and not to me. But **I** wanted to know what it was called. Acute Lymphoblastic Leukemia. That's a name for a ***really*** bad monster. Like the kind that probably live in closets. But it's actually the name for a Really Bad Cancer -- a cancer that kids don't get better from. I told Mom that I wasn't scared, but I was actually lying a little bit.

Mr. Burp told me it was really important for me to be strong for Mom and Dad and

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Gram. Gram was here yesterday and I told her that Mr. Burp had come back. That he was here with me and that he just had to go away for a little while to get things ready. And she wasn't surprised at all.

(changing the subject) Mom told me that I'm going to have a little brother. And I told her that I'm going to be watching him from Heaven and that I'll be waiting for him. And Mom said, "I know, sweetheart. I know." The cool thing is, Mr. Burp's gonna visit him too. *(peeks under her bed, then whispers)*

I need you to be really quiet, because Mr. Burp is sleeping right now. He told me a secret. He told me that because he's magic, he can go wherever he wants, anytime. Not like people. And so, he's going to go with me and I don't have to be afraid. *(takes a deep breath and put on her brave face)* I'm not. I'm just really, really tired.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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